

Design Guidelines

How to create and deliver a design for a MONO tee: one ink, black or white cotton, printed large on the back. Everything you need to make a design that prints well and passes our review first time.

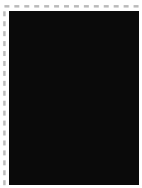
01 What we print

- **One ink.** Every design is printed in a single colour. No second colour, no gradients, no grey. Tones are made with dots or lines (halftone, hatching, stippling).
- **On the back.** The print sits high on the back of the tee, centred.
- **Black and white tees.** A design is offered on a black tee (printed in white ink) and on a white tee (printed in black ink). If your design only works on one of them, tell us.

What makes a good MONO design: strong line work, clear shapes and plenty of air. Think engraving, botanical plate, map, diagram, woodcut, typography, pattern, or a photograph turned into dots. The tee's colour is part of the design: leave room for it to show.

02 Design area: portrait, 26 × 35 cm

Design in portrait, not landscape. The design area is 26 cm wide by 35 cm tall: taller than it is wide, like the back of the tee. Compose your artwork to fill this upright shape.



26 cm wide
35 cm tall

✓ Portrait: fills the design area



26 cm wide
only ~17 cm tall

× Landscape: prints small, half the area empty

ITEM	SIZE (WIDTH × HEIGHT)
Design area (portrait)	26 × 35 cm, the size your artwork should fill
Full print area	28 × 37 cm; the extra centimetre on every side is a safety margin, keep artwork out of it
Small placement (optional)	12 × 12 cm square
Position	Centred left to right. The top of the design starts about 1 cm below the top of the print area

- The width is the limit: a design is never printed wider than 26 cm. A wide (landscape) artwork is scaled down to that width and ends up short, leaving the lower back empty.
- Align your design to the **top** of the area, not the middle. Don't leave a large empty band above it.

- The design should be substantial: at least 30% of the width and 30% of the height of the area. A thin strip across the chest or down the spine won't be accepted.

03 Files

Line art, type, geometry and patterns: vector (preferred)

- SVG, with a PDF or AI copy.
- One colour only (100% black). Transparent background, with no background rectangle.
- All text converted to outlines.
- No embedded images, gradients, transparency, effects, shadows or complex masks.
- Artboard: 26 × 35 cm, portrait (the design area). If you work on the full 28 × 37 cm area, keep all artwork inside the central 26 × 35 cm.

Photographs, engravings, brush and scanned work: raster

- PNG with a transparent background.
- 300 DPI at print size: 3071 × 4134 px (portrait) for the design area, 1417 × 1417 px for the small placement.
- 1-bit (ink or nothing), or greyscale that has already been screened into dots or lines. A continuous-tone greyscale photo cannot be printed in one ink.

Two tee colours

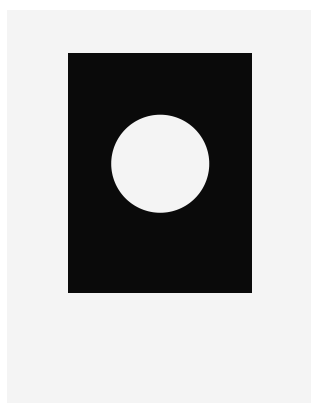
- **Line art:** one file is enough. We print it in white on black tees and in black on white tees.
- **Photographs and any tonal work:** send two positives, because inverting a photo inverts its meaning:
 - ...-black.png: what prints in white ink on a black tee (the light parts of the picture are the ink);
 - ...-white.png: what prints in black ink on a white tee.

04 Ink: how much, and where

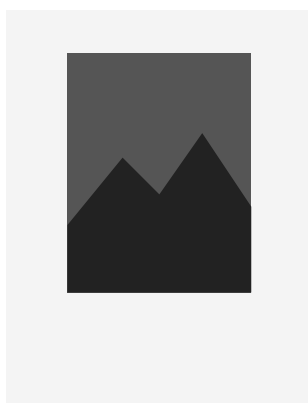
Every design is checked for these before it goes on sale. A design that fails is returned with the reason.

RULE	LIMIT
Total ink coverage	Between 4% and 32% of the print area
Solid ink	Areas of solid ink wider than about 4 mm may cover no more than 10% of the area in total, and no single solid patch more than 3%
Rectangles and panels	No filled rectangle, panel or box of ink, and no full background with the motif cut out of it (knockout)
Photographs and scenes	The subject cut out, or the scene given one of the endings below: never the whole picture with its background
Dense areas	No continuous dense area (ink over about half of every 6 mm) larger than 15% of the print. On the black-tee file a pale sky stays tee, not ink
Edges	Ink must not run along all four edges of the print area
Frames and paper	No dark vignette around an empty middle, no scanned paper edges or shadows

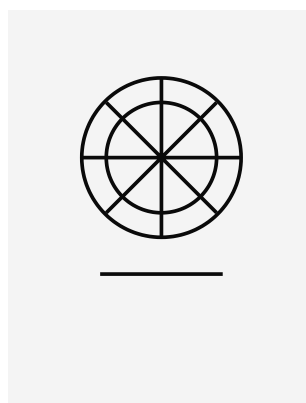
The simple test: if your design lands on the tee as a *rectangle of ink*, like a sticker, it won't pass. Open line work, dotted halftones, thin frames around line grids and cut-out subjects all pass.



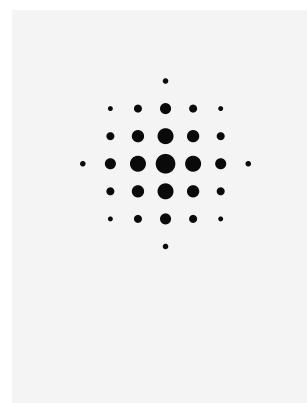
× Knockout panel



× Photo with its background



✓ Open line work



✓ Halftone fading out

Scenes: how a picture ends

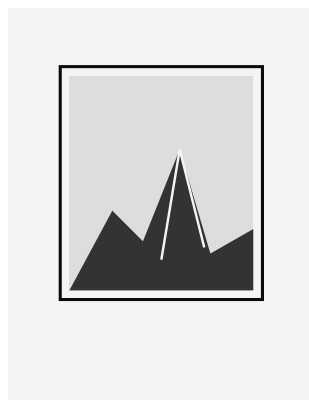
A scene drawn to its edges (a landscape, a coast, a sky) must end somewhere other than a rectangle of ink. Choose one ending per design, before you draw, and compose for it:

ENDING	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	SUITS
Horizon (the default)	The ground ends in one straight cut with a thin rule under it; the sides fall away and the sky is simply not drawn	Mountains, cliffs, dunes, a lighthouse
Plate	Cut to a rectangle with a thin keyline round it, like a museum plate or a postcard	Busy scenes: a forest, a lake, a fjord
Circle	Cut to a circle with a thin ring, like a lens or a seal	The moon, an island, a geyser, a planet
Arch	A rectangle with a round top and a keyline, like a window	Waterfalls, canyons, tall towers
Vignette	A soft fade to nothing all round	Sparingly: at most one design in ten, and only where it looks right

Keylines are a single thin line (0.5–1 mm) a few millimetres off the picture: a frame, never a filled box. Inside any ending, a plain light area (an empty sky) prints as nothing on the black tee.



✓ Horizon



✓ Plate



✓ Circle



✓ Arch

05 Lines, dots and text

ELEMENT	MINIMUM / RECOMMENDED
Line weight	Minimum 0.4 mm (thinner lines don't print reliably). A good hierarchy: 0.5 / 0.75 / 1.1 / 1.7 mm for hairline, fine, regular and bold
Halftone dots and the gaps between them	Minimum 0.4 mm
Text: capital height	Minimum 2.5 mm; 4 mm or more for text that must be read
Small detail	Any enclosed detail smaller than 0.4 mm will fill in when printed: simplify it

06 Words and type

- **Fonts:** only fonts licensed for commercial use on products (for example, SIL Open Font License). Tell us the font and its licence.
- **Language:** British English (colour, centre, metres). Typographic apostrophes and quotation marks (' " "), not straight ones (' ").
- **Not allowed:** brand names, logos, trademarks, copyrighted quotes or lyrics, and names of private individuals.

07 Rights

- Your own original work, or material in the **public domain** or under **CC0**. Licences that require attribution or forbid commercial use only by prior agreement.
- For archive material (museum and library collections), include the link to the source, the item number, the creator, the date and the licence.
- Photographs of people only with a model release, or when the photograph is in the public domain.
- Images made with generative tools: tell us which tool, and confirm its terms allow commercial use.
- By submitting, you confirm you have the right to grant **MONO** the rights to print and sell the design.

08 Details for each design

FIELD	WHAT TO WRITE
Title	In English, up to 40 characters, Title Case. Example: “The Fourteen Eight-Thousanders”
Category	One of: Photographs · Botanical & Nature · Maps & Sky · Architecture · Engravings · Brush & Woodblock · Pattern · Geometric · Type · ASCII & Code
Subject	What it shows, in a word or two. Example: Mountains
Style	Example: Halftone, Line drawing, Woodcut
Medium	Drawn (vector or illustration), photograph or scan
Description	One or two sentences in British English: what we see and where it comes from
Tee colours	Black, white, or both
Print size	The design’s actual width × height in cm
Keywords	5 to 10 search words
Credit and source	Source and licence, where relevant

09 Delivery

One folder per design, zipped. File names in English, lower case, words joined by hyphens, no spaces.

<code>yourname-short-title/</code>	
<code>short-title.svg</code>	(or <code>short-title-black.png</code> + <code>short-title-white.png</code>)
<code>short-title-preview.png</code>	1500 px wide, the design on a black or white background
<code>short-title.txt</code>	the details from section 08
<code>sources/</code>	source files and licences, where relevant

10 Checklist before you submit

- ☐ One colour, transparent background, no gradients or grey
- ☐ Portrait design, 26 cm wide × 35 cm tall, aligned to the top
- ☐ Vector with text outlined, or PNG at 300 DPI (3071 × 4134 px, portrait)
- ☐ Tonal work: two positives, -black and -white
- ☐ Ink coverage between 4% and 32%; no rectangles, panels or full backgrounds
- ☐ Lines and dots at least 0.4 mm; capital height at least 2.5 mm
- ☐ Fonts and materials licensed for commercial use, sources included
- ☐ All details from section 08 filled in